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Global Markets Research
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China e-commerce

EQUITY: INTERNET & NEW MEDIA

China e-commerce market stagnant in September

Quick Note

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China e-commerce sales remained flat y-y in September

The National Bureau of Statistics (NBS) on 19 October 2026 released China's retail sales data for September 2026. China's retail sales (excluding auto sales) grew 3.9% y-y to CNY3.9tn in September, accelerating from 2.5% in August, during which China's e-commerce sales (excluding sales of services) remained flat at 0.1% y-y, decelerating meaningfully from 2.2% y-y growth in August. According to our calculation, average e-commerce growth in 3Q26 was 1.8% y-y, decelerating from 2.3% y-y in 2Q26. E-commerce penetration in China dipped 0.3pp y-y to 28.7% in September, marking the first decline since July 2025. The weak e-commerce sales were in line with the guidance provided by major e-commerce platforms. We think the China e-commerce industry has mostly tightened subsidy spending to preserve their cash flows in view of cautious consumer sentiment.

Based on NBS data, China's online food and beverage sales rose 15.8% y-y in 9M26, largely on par with the 15.9% in 8M26. Online apparel sales recorded a 3.4% y-y increase, down from 4.9% in 8M26. Online sales of household goods increased 0.8% y-y in 9M26, down from 1.1% in 8M26.

In terms of sales for the entire retail market (including both online and offline), within staples, food sales and daily necessities categories rose 6.7% and 4.1% y-y, respectively, in September, accelerating from corresponding gains of 4.0% and 1.8% y-y in August. Beverage sales recorded 5.0% y-y growth in September, largely on par with the 4.9% y-y growth in August.

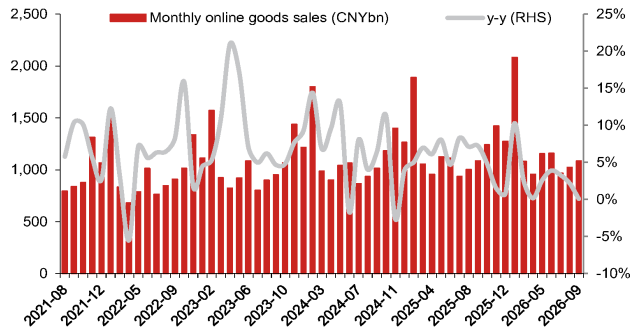
Within the discretionary category, most subcategory recorded accelerating y-y growth in September. Sales of smart devices (smartphones and smart glasses etc) continued to accelerate, reaching 31.1% y-y growth in September, accelerating from 27.3% in August. Based on our chats with industry contacts, we think the strength in this category was likely helped by cost-driven price hikes and trade-in subsidies that included smart glasses and other AI-enable consumer electronics in the eligible categories for such subsidies, which were able to offset the volume weakness. PC sales increased 7.9% y-y in September, accelerating from 5.8% in August. Cosmetic sales recorded 5.4% y-y growth in September, accelerating from 4.9% y-y in August, while the apparel category recovered to 1.2% y-y growth in September, returning from the 0.5% y-y decline in August. However, the home appliance category recorded 1.9% y-y growth in September, slipping from 2.3% y-y in August.

Our top picks in the China internet space are Alibaba (BABA US, Buy), Tencent (700 HK, Buy), and Meituan (3690 HK, Buy).

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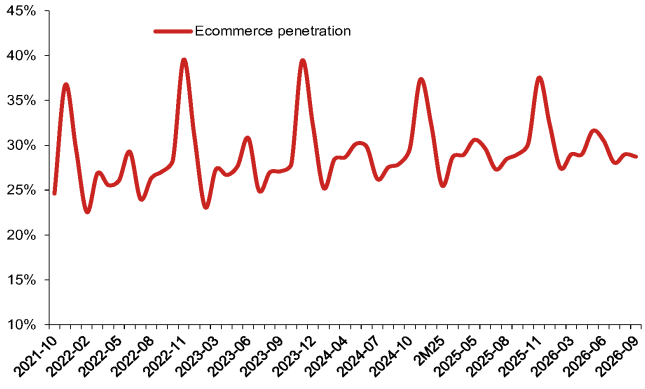
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Fig. 1: China: Monthly online goods sales and y-y growth



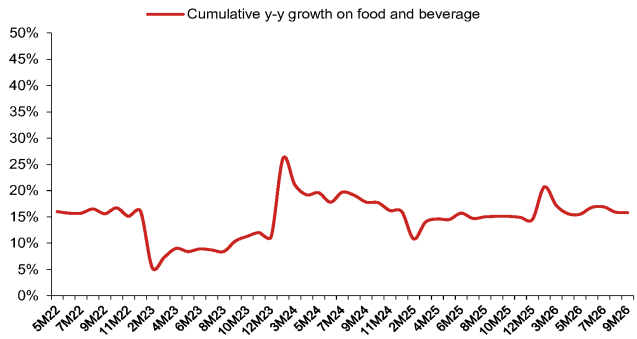
Note: Excluding sales of virtual goods.
Source: NBS, Nomura research

Fig. 2: E-commerce as a percentage of total retail sales



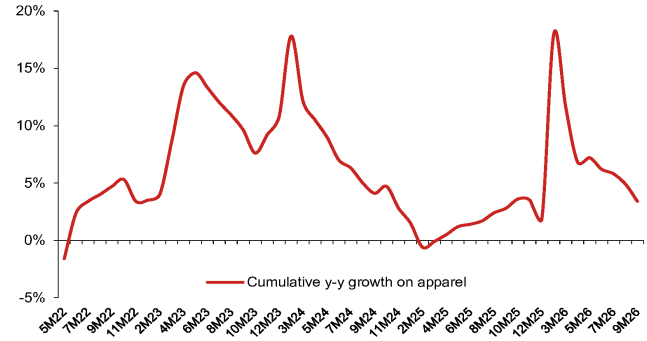
Note: Excluding sales of virtual goods.
Source: NBS, Nomura research

Fig. 3: Cumulative y-y growth of online retail sales of food and beverages



Source: NBS, Nomura research

Fig. 4: Cumulative y-y growth of online retail sales of apparel



Source: NBS, Nomura research

Appendix A-1

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Issuer	Ticker	Price	Price date	Stock rating	Sector rating	Disclosures
Meituan	3690 HK	HKD 75.70	16-Oct-2026	Buy	N/A	A10
Tencent Holdings	700 HK	HKD 417.80	16-Oct-2026	Buy	N/A	A1,A3,A10
Alibaba Group Holding	BABA US	USD 109.11	16-Oct-2026	Buy	N/A	A10

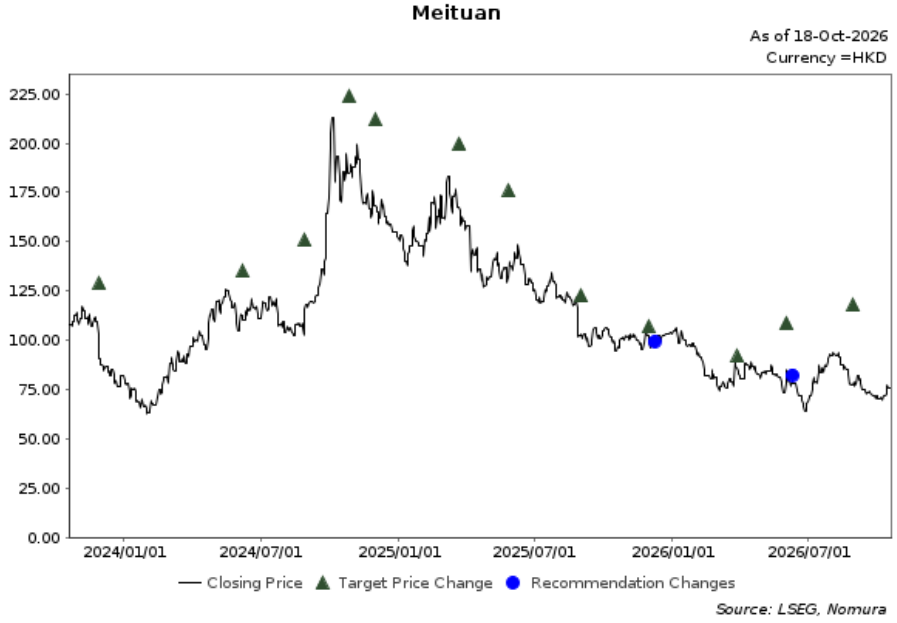
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Meituan (3690 HK) **HKD 75.70 (16-Oct-2026)** Buy (Sector rating: N/A)

Rating and target price chart (three year history)



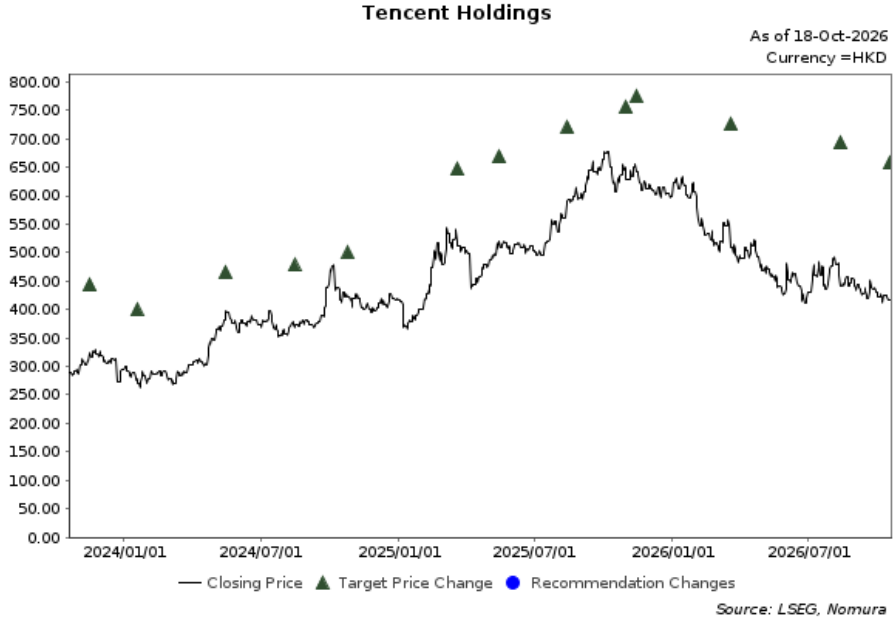
Date	Rating	Target price	Closing price
30-Aug-26		118.00	77.50
02-Jun-26	Buy		85.50
02-Jun-26		109.00	85.50
29-Mar-26		92.00	85.90
30-Nov-25	Neutral		102.50
30-Nov-25		107.00	102.50
01-Sep-25		123.00	103.00
28-May-25		176.00	131.40
23-Mar-25		200.00	167.60
01-Dec-24		212.00	168.70
27-Oct-24		224.00	184.90
29-Aug-24		151.00	115.70
07-Jun-24		135.00	110.40
29-Nov-23		129.00	90.45

For explanation of ratings refer to the stock rating keys located after chart(s)

Valuation Methodology We value the food delivery business at USD25bn based on 8x FY28F P/E and discounted to FY27. We value the instashopping business at USD7bn based on 15x FY27F normalized P/E. We value the in-store, hotel and travel business at USD15bn based on 5x FY27F P/E. We value the new business at USD24bn, based on 1.0x FY27F P/S. The resulting TP is HKD118. The benchmark index for the stock is the Hang Seng Index.
Risks that may impede the achievement of the target price Downside risks include: (1) intensifying competition in the food delivery or in-store consumption verticals; and (2) worse-than-expected performance in the new initiatives.

Tencent Holdings (700 HK) **HKD 417.80 (16-Oct-2026)** Buy (Sector rating: N/A)

Rating and target price chart (three year history)



Date	Rating	Target price	Closing price
18-Oct-26		659.00	417.80
13-Aug-26		695.00	441.00
20-Mar-26		727.00	508.00
14-Nov-25		775.00	641.00
31-Oct-25		757.00	629.00
14-Aug-25		721.00	590.00
15-May-25		670.00	520.00
20-Mar-25		648.00	519.50
25-Oct-24		500.00	421.00
15-Aug-24		478.00	368.40
15-May-24		467.00	381.80
18-Jan-24		400.00	277.60
16-Nov-23		445.00	324.80

For explanation of ratings refer to the stock rating keys located after chart(s)

Valuation Methodology We value Tencent's online gaming business at USD259bn (FY27F P/E of 15x), online advertising business at USD259bn (FY27F P/E of 18x), Fintech business at USD119bn (FY27F P/E of 10x), and Cloud business at USD55bn (FY27F P/S of 5x). We value investees at USD65bn. The resulting TP is HKD659. The benchmark for the stock is the Hang Seng Index.
Risks that may impede the achievement of the target price Risks: High market expectations, aggressive spending on WeChat Pay and overseas marketing, and any potentially disruptive products and business models from competitors.

Alibaba Group Holding (BABA US) **USD 109.11 (16-Oct-2026)** Buy (Sector rating: N/A)

Rating and target price chart (three year history)



Date	Rating	Target price	Closing price
24-Jun-26		178.00	99.80
14-May-26		207.00	141.12
20-Mar-26		200.00	122.41
23-Jan-26		237.00	173.23
09-Jan-26		193.00	150.96
08-Oct-25		215.00	181.12
01-Sep-25		170.00	135.00
09-Jul-25		152.00	103.83
21-Feb-25		172.00	142.62
18-Nov-24		130.00	88.65
10-Oct-24		135.00	108.42
16-Aug-24		106.00	82.52
09-Apr-24		101.00	71.80
08-Feb-24		103.00	69.63
10-Jan-24		117.00	70.25
17-Nov-23		134.00	76.34

For explanation of ratings refer to the stock rating keys located after chart(s)

Valuation Methodology We value Alibaba's Ecommerce Group at USD102bn, based on 5x FY28F P/E; its AliCloud (ex T-head chips) business at USD190bn, based on 5x FY28F P/S; its T-head chips business at USD85bn, based on 13x FY28F P/S, and its net valuation of non-core assets at USD28bn. The resulting TP is USD178. The benchmark index for this stock is Nasdaq Composite.
Risks that may impede the achievement of the target price Downside risks include: lower-than-expected Alicloud revenue growth; margin downside due to ramp-up in investments; regulatory risks related to the payment and internet finance industry, which could hurt Alibaba's main business and its value in Ant Group.

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